



The Exhibit Promo Tool

A concept project to promote our open calls and exhibitions — and attract more submissions. This deck explains the project, what we already own, and the **decisions to make before we build.**

Concept · Pre-build

Graduated from Idea 011

Not Real Art · Artsville · Arterial

WHAT THIS PROJECT IS

A Concept, Graduated From the Ideas Inbox

The ideas-inbox captures, researches, and evaluates ideas before they become projects. Idea 011 — Owned Promotion & PR Engine reached "Recommend Pilot" — so it graduates here into its own concept repo to be designed properly.

✓ Done in this repo

Background & education · the systems map · the 66-channel directory · a PressRanger product deep-dive · the build-vs-integrate analysis · a decision register

⌚ Still to come

Use cases · user-centric tasks · the press-release / PressRanger integration design · the per-call promotion checklist — *all blocked on the key decisions*

⌚ Not yet

No code. No build. We are deliberately deciding **what** to build and **where** before writing any.

WHY WE'RE DOING THIS

We Run Open Calls — We Don't Promote Them

We're excellent at *running* open calls and exhibitions, and almost nothing promotes them beyond our own small email list. **Submission volume is the lever** — it compounds into better shows, a bigger community, press leverage, and nonprofit public support.

No repository

Press & outreach contacts live in inboxes and people's heads.

No active owner

Promotion is whoever-has-time — so it mostly doesn't happen.

No PR cadence

Releases go out sporadically — not before, on, and after each call.

The evidence it works: the grant campaigns over-performed because we ran **Facebook ads to the landing pages**. Open calls deserve the same treatment — measured, this time. → [research/01-why-promote-open-calls.md](#)

THE FRAMING THAT DECIDES EVERYTHING

It's Three Layers, Not One App

Most of the "which app do we build this on?" debate dissolves once you see this isn't one application — it's three layers, each with a different natural home.

Engine

Content gen → approval →
schedule → publish → paid ads.

Already exists: PolyWiz

Data + CRM

Contacts, pitches, coverage, registry,
open-call & submission data.

Partly exists: Airtable

Packaging

Who it's for, how it's sold: internal ·
multi-brand · white-label.

A choice — not yet made

"Which app" becomes "which layer goes where" — and only packaging is genuinely open.

WHAT WE ALREADY OWN

The Stack Is the Spine — We Rent Only Inputs

PressRanger

owned feed — swappable
Journalist DB + pitch radar



PolyWiz

the engine — our spine
Gen · approval · schedule · publish (14
platforms) · ads



Artwork Archive

Airtable system-of-record
Open-call records + submissions =
conversion signal

"Open Call" is already a scaffolded PolyWiz campaign type
— disabled, ~1 hour to enable organic. Press release = a new
output format. Paid ads = polywiz-app#181.

Same principle as Idea 009: own the engine; rent only
swappable inputs. → [research/03-related-systems.md](#)

THE DEMAND LAYER

66 Verified Channels, Mostly Free & Unused

Before building anything, we mapped where to promote calls and find funding — every row drives artists back to *our own* submission page. 43 of 66 are free.

24

Fundraising / grants / donor

18

Open-call listings

15

Media / PR amplifiers

6

Partner orgs / councils

3

Paid-ads channels

Each row carries an action URL, cost, self-service level, effort — and a ready-made **UTM slug** so every promoted link is attributable. → [research/04-channel-directory.md](#) · [research/arts-master-resource.csv](#)

THE REALITY CHECK ON PRESSRANGER

It Can't Be a Live Feed — CSV Export Only

PressRanger's media database + CRM + AI would cost \$3K-\$40K/yr elsewhere, and we own it on a lifetime deal. But for *integrating* it, the deep-dive surfaced a hard constraint:

No API • No Zapier • No webhooks

The only integration is a Claude MCP server — and it exposes **only your own companies + draft releases**, never the contact database.

Egress = manual CSV, tier-capped

~4,000 records/mo on our Tier 3. So integration is a **periodic batch ETL** — export → Airtable import — not a live sync.

Plus noisy keyword-matched beats and patchy emails (one test: **8 of 100** contacts had an email). Use it for **discovery**; own the CRM ourselves. → [research/05-pressranger-deep-dive.md](#)

BUILD VS. INTEGRATE

No Clone to Fork — Build Thin on Our Stack

A full GitHub sweep found **no forkable PressRanger** — only SEO-spam repos and zero-star hackathon agents. PressRanger's moat is its *journalist database*, which is proprietary and *not our use case*: we manage our **own** contacts.

Recommendation

Build a **thin CRM on Next.js + Airtable + Claude + n8n**:
Contacts · Pitches · Coverage · Registry. Keep PressRanger as a swappable discovery feed.

Don't over-build

Adopting a heavyweight CRM (Twenty, EspoCRM) adds a second datastore, auth, and self-host burden to replace what Airtable already does. **Simplicity first.**

Revisit Twenty only if we outgrow Airtable. → [research/06-build-vs-integrate-and-oss-landscape.md](#)

THE DECISIONS BEFORE WE BUILD

Seven Questions — One of Them Is the Root

Before use cases or schemas, the team (Scott · Elise · Juergen) has to answer a set of architectural & strategic questions. Most of them lean the same way — **except one, which everything else hangs on.**

The root question — Decision 5

Are we building a **tool** (internal, promote our own calls) — or a **product** (white-label PR-as-a-service for other arts orgs)?

Almost every other decision reads "lean X if internal, lean Y if product." Answer this first and the rest resolve.

Full reasoning, options, and tradeoffs → [concept/00-key-decisions.md](#)

DECISION 1 — WHERE THE ENGINE LIVES

PolyWiz "Campaign Type" — Not a New App

LEAN ✓

PolyWiz campaign type

It already *is* the engine. "Open Call" is scaffolded; press release = new output format; ads = #181.

Artwork Archive utility

Holds the data — but has **no** AI gen, publishing, or ads. Building here = rebuilding PolyWiz. It's a *data* home.

Standalone PR app

Cleanest separation — and the right shell *if* we go white-label. Otherwise it duplicates the engine we own.

Data + CRM layer → a cleanly-namespaced Airtable (the Artwork Archive base). "Artwork Archive as a CRM utility" is true for the *data*, not the *engine*.

Internal Tool, or White-Label SaaS?

Scott's instinct: *"turn it into some kind of service for artists or galleries."* And PressRanger is already white-label/reseller-ready — so a service could be largely **resell + our playbook + our brand.**

A • Internal only

Smallest build, fastest value. Leaves the revenue instinct on the table.

LEAN ✓

B • Internal now, product-ready

Prove the playbook on ourselves first; keep data portable + brands agnostic. Low-regret. Most of the "keep-open" work our rules already mandate.

C • White-label day one

Pays the multi-tenant + billing + support cost **before** the playbook is proven. High risk.

Review alongside Idea 004 (Multi-Tenant) + Idea 009 (Owned Platform) — white-label PR may belong with those.

DECISIONS AT A GLANCE

Seven Leans — All Gated by the Root

#	DECISION	LEAN	GATED BY
1	Engine host	PolyWiz campaign type	#5
2	Data / CRM host	Airtable — Artwork Archive base, namespaced	#5
3	One product or two	Two layered capabilities	#5
4	Multi-brand vs. multi-tenant	Multi-brand now, tenant-ready	#5
5	Internal vs. white-label	Internal now, product-ready — THE ROOT	—
6	User surface (Elise)	Reuse PolyWiz + Airtable; no new app yet	#5
7	PressRanger role	Swappable discovery feed	settled

Answer #5 — even as "tool for now, revisit after Phase 1" — and 1–4 + 6 resolve to these leans.

THE RECOMMENDATION

The Low-Regret Path

- 1 Build the engine capability in PolyWiz — enable "Open Call," add press-release output, wire the #181 ads pilot. Reversible — it's our engine either way.
- 2 Build the thin CRM/registry in a clean Airtable — Contacts · Pitches · Coverage · Registry. Brand-agnostic, portable — lifts into a tenant base later if needed.
- 3 Run Phase 1 on one real call (*Art of Resistance*) with a ~\$250 paid flight — and measure cost-per-submission for the first time.
- 4 Defer the white-label decision until that data exists — then decide tool-vs-product with evidence.

Every step delivers internal value *and* is a prerequisite for the product version. Deferring costs nothing.

READ THE FULL THINKING

Where Everything Lives

RESEARCH (THE WHY & WHAT EXISTS)

- 01 · why promote open calls
- 02 · background & context
- 03 · related systems
- 04 · channel directory (+ CSV)
- 05 · PressRanger deep-dive
- 06 · build-vs-integrate landscape

CONCEPT (THE DECISIONS & DESIGN)

- 00 · key decisions ← start here
 - use cases (to come)
 - user-centric tasks (to come)
 - PressRanger integration (to come)
 - promotion checklist (to come)

UPSTREAM LINEAGE

- Idea 011 — this concept's parent
- Idea 007 — paid-ads engine
- Idea 009 — own-the-layer
- Idea 004 — multi-tenant
- polywiz-app#181 — ads epic



One Question Unblocks the Rest

We already own the engine, the data hub, and the feed. The research is done; the decisions are framed. The single thing standing between "questions" and "design" is one answer: **are we building a tool, or a product?**

Answer that, and I can start the use-cases, schema, and integration design. — Juergen Berkessel, Polymash